Zero-Click Marketing and AI Search Visibility

Title: Zero-Click Marketing and AI Search Visibility
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Abstract: Buyers still search. A rising share of those searches never produce a click. In the US, SparkToro's Similarweb-based analysis found 68.01% of Google searches ended without a click in January–April 2026 — up from about 60% in 2024. When Google shows an AI summary, Pew's 2025 browsing study found people clicked a traditional result in 8% of visits versus 15% without a summary, and clicked a link inside the summary in only 1% of visits. This paper argues founders and B2B marketers should treat search as a behaviour, not only a traffic channel, and build AI search visibility with three moves: a focused claim set, a proof map with a public trail across owned and third-party sources, and a testing loop that strengthens weak evidence instead of shipping more thin content.

1. The problem: more searching, fewer visits
Growth teams long treated organic search as a pipeline: rank, win the click, convert on a page you own. That path still exists. It is no longer the default finish.
Measured zero-click rates: Early 2026 (US): 68.01% (SparkToro/Similarweb Jan–Apr 2026). 2024: 58.5% US / 59.7% EU (SparkToro/Datos). AI Overviews accelerate the finish; Pew found traditional clicks 8% vs 15% with/without AI summary; summary-source clicks 1%.

2. Why content calendars alone fail
Teams that treat AI visibility as "post more" get activity without recommendations. Models reuse language that is clear, repeated, and corroborated. The question: when a serious buyer asks which companies solve this problem, do you get named with a clear role and proof?

3. Operating system: three moves
3.1 Focused claim set — who for, problem owned, proof, what you refuse to be. Same language on site, sales, PR, social.
3.2 Proof map and public trail — each claim needs owned asset plus third-party corroboration.
3.3 Parallel execution: earned media + on-site GEO.
3.4 Test what buyers see — ~25 prompts, sample ≥2 assistants monthly.

4. 90-day checklist
1. Lock niche + claim set. 2. Build 25 prompts; sample two AIs monthly. 3. List earned destinations in those answers. 4. Align website and profiles. 5. Ship three owned assets. 6.

Land one newsworthy PR moment. 7. Publish researched guides. 8. Review AI-referred sessions on conversion quality.

5. Program takeaways
1. Method for a focused claim set humans and models can understand.
2. Proof map + public trail (owned + independent).
3. Testing loop that replaces “more content” with stronger evidence.

6. Closing
Companies that win make brands easy to understand, cite, and verify.